Reform as Process:

Implementing Change in Public Bureaucracies

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Book Abstract

Building an effective civil service is crucial for public service delivery and good governance, but reforming bureaucratic institutions is notoriously difficult. This book takes a fresh perspective on this challenge by documenting and analyzing the implementation of more than one hundred reforms initiated by six African countries over the last thirty years. I show that these reforms largely fell short of their goals, because they typically approached organizational change as a matter of changing formal structures and processes through one-off projects. However, many of these reform efforts did yield positive changes when they were able to create energy and opportunities for civil servants to discuss performance and how to improve it. I draw on this evidence to outline a theory of how systemic reforms can lead to meaningful change not by forcing it through top-down interventions but by catalyzing an ongoing process of continuous improvement. The book makes theoretical and empirical contributions to academic literatures on government performance, public service delivery, and development, and discusses practical insights and strategies for reformers around the world to achieve change in practice.

Chapter One

The Puzzle of Reform

Congratulations! You've just been appointed an advisor to the Head of the Civil Service. Your job is to make recommendations about how to improve the effectiveness of dozens of government ministries and departments, which are in turn responsible for delivering public services, developing policies, building infrastructure, implementing regulations, and nearly everything else the economy and society depend on. But your civil service is widely perceived – by civil servants, politicians, and ordinary people alike – as ineffective, even dysfunctional. Budgets are tight, and there are major political and legal constraints on your ability to hire or fire personnel. How would you advise the Head of Civil Service to go about designing and implementing reforms to improve the performance of the civil service?

This question represents one of the most pressing practical problems facing governments around the world. But it also poses an intellectual challenge of the first order. Ultimately, civil service reforms aim to change the day-to-day behavior and routines of the huge number of people that collectively make its decisions, enforce its rules, and deliver its services. But government is not a machine with simple levers that produce predictable responses when pulled. It is a complex system of interdependent organizations and teams inhabited by a diverse range of people, each with their own interests, preferences, experiences, and biases. The wrecks of failed reforms that litter the junkyard of public administration history can testify to the difficulty of transforming bureaucracies. What can we learn from this history of reform efforts about the prospects for systemic reform to improve the inner workings of government?

This book aims to answer these questions by documenting and analyzing how six countries in Africa have repeatedly sought to reform their civil services over the past three decades. These countries have been global hotbeds of experimentation in public administration reform, collectively undertaking over 100 performance-oriented reforms during this period. The types of problems they have sought to solve and the solutions they've attempted to adopt and implement will be familiar to reformers around the world. These reforms have been driven at times by public servants and other times by donors or politicians, or often combinations of two or three of these. And they have been influenced by global trends as well as homegrown ideas.

So public managers and researchers from around the world have much to learn from the history and patterns of reform in these six countries.

To do this, I use a rich range of primary and secondary data to document the content, process, implementation, outcomes, and politics of each of these reform efforts. I then use this comprehensive portrait of reform efforts to identify repeated patterns in design, implementation, and outcomes that recur across many reforms, across all six countries, and across time. Of course, every reform effort and context is unique to some extent, and when we look at each reform in isolation there are many potential explanations for why events unfolded as they did. But if we don't look historically and comparatively across efforts and across contexts, we risk missing the forest for the trees. Beyond these particularities and idiosyncrasies, are there repeated patterns we can identify and learn from?

I argue that there were two features that characterized the vast majority of large-scale reform efforts, and that helped explain the persistently disappointing results of these reforms. First, most reforms focused mainly on changing formal structures, rules, and processes. This took different forms across different reforms, but the common thread was an emphasis on creating formal processes that would compel or incentivize bureaucrats to behave differently. Second, reforms were typically conceived of and executed as discrete, one-off, often time-bound interventions into a system. This meant that reforms often ended up as projects with their own pre-defined workplans, acronyms, timetables, budget lines, and implementation teams. In other cases they took the form of new laws or structures on paper that in practice were implemented halfheartedly (if at all), or that had purchase for a year or two before fading away. Together, these constituted the two main *mechanisms of failure* of reforms. I demonstrate how and why this approach was largely ineffective at changing the complex system of organizations, rules, and perceptions that constitute government bureaucracy, and undermined the potential of reforms to change the way that bureaucrats think about and carry out their work on an everyday basis.

At the same time, the history of reforms is much more than a story of failure – most reforms did achieve something, even if they fell short of their goals. While reforms tended to make more changes on paper than in practice, some reforms did have positive and meaningful impacts on actual day-to-day work practices of civil servants. When they did so, it was usually through two linked *mechanisms of success*: creating opportunities for civil servants to discuss

performance and how to improve it with each other, and building energy and momentum to do so. These mechanisms of success worked not because they forced unwilling bureaucrats to improve their performance, but because they helped create an environment where bureaucrats who wanted their teams and organizations to work better were able to find ways to make this happen. Though these mechanisms of success often coexisted with mechanisms of failure within the same reform effort, they usually took a back-seat role in the dominant reform approach.

If this is the diagnosis the explains the track record of past efforts at reform, what is the prescription for how future reformers should approach their work differently? What can we learn from this history to help us better advise a Head of Civil Service or other prospective reform leader how they should go about improving performance across a whole bureaucratic system?

I argue that instead of treating reform as a one-off change to formal processes, reformers should approach it as *catalyzing an ongoing process of continuous improvement in actual practices*. This alternative approach reframes the goal of reform as the improvement of day-to-day bureaucratic behaviors, both in terms of adherence to formal processes as well as the undertaking of the many tasks that are important for performance but can't be fully codified on paper. It reconceptualizes how to implement reform, as an open-ended process of collective learning-by-doing that must be ongoing in order to get people to make these behavior changes. And it casts the task of reform leadership in a different light, as a matter of enabling and supporting decentralized change at numerous points throughout the bureaucratic system rather than of trying to legislate it or force it from above. This approach of *reform as process* aims to minimize the mechanisms of failure and maximize the mechanisms of success that have characterized past reform efforts, and serve as a viable alternative for the many reformers and researchers who are seeking a different – and hopefully better – way to make change in public bureaucracies.

Of course, there are many practical and political challenges to approaching reform as a process. The book discusses these obstacles and how to navigate them, based in large part on evidence from reform leaders who have experimented with these ideas, and whose thoughts and efforts have helped inspire this book. Even so, it is definitely not easy, perhaps not even always achievable. But it represents a more promising approach – grounded in evidence, theory, and

illustrative examples – to a challenge that has confounded generations of reformers and researchers alike and that represents one of the main barriers to improving performance in government organizations around Africa and worldwide.

The question I posed above – how you should advise the Head of Civil Service to go about designing and implementing reforms – isn't just a hypothetical scenario. In 2014, I sat in the office of Ghana's newly appointed Head of Civil Service, Nana Agyekum-Dwamena, who said to me: "I've got five years, and I want to change the way this place works. But I want to do it in an evidence-based way." Agyekum-Dwamena brought nearly 30 years of experience in Ghana's Civil Service to approaching this challenge, but as a scholar I felt uncomfortably limited in my ability to contribute either a broad and rigorous view of the evidence or a straightforward set of theoretical insights on designing and implementing system-level bureaucratic reforms. Given the complexity and context-dependence of such reforms, I wasn't even sure what an answer to this question would look like.

This book represents my effort to grapple with this challenge – to be able to offer stronger evidence and more useful conceptual frameworks to the numerous smart, dedicated, and experienced civil servants searching for insight to help them improve the effectiveness of their institutions. Doing so throws up an interesting set of puzzles and opportunities for researchers. This process has involved collecting and analyzing a great deal of new data, as well as synthesizing and learning from the immense amount of research already conducted on these issues by academics and practitioners from Africa and around the world.[1] I have tried to do this in a way that amplifies and complements this existing work on reform design and implementation and connects it to the rapidly growing adjacent literatures on bureaucratic performance, state capacity, organizational change, long-term development, and complex systems. While I think the book makes some novel theoretical and empirical contributions, it also reports on and builds on a great deal of insight from other researchers, and I have done my best to highlight these intellectual lineages and debts throughout the book.

I have also sought to draw as much as possible on the experience of practitioners themselves, not just as data points but also as deep theoretical insights. To the extent this book succeeds at its goals, it is largely because the generosity of numerous civil servants has enabled me to benefit from their ideas and to bring their experiences into conversation with each other across countries and across time. Many of them are also frustrated with the shortcomings of past

reform efforts, and have long been actively thinking about and experimenting with alternatives. Their perspectives on these issues are naturally diverse and often contradict each other, and of course the responsibility for the book's analysis and synthesis of this vast range of ideas and evidence rests with me. Nevertheless, I hope that they – and other readers who have tried to make change in government bureaucracies, or large organizations anywhere – see some of their experiences reflected in what I have written, together with a deep respect for their work.

Most of all, I hope that this book can help revitalize and recenter the study of large-scale bureaucratic reforms in social science research and policy thinking. Recent years have seen a general shift away from asking "big questions" towards focusing on more narrowly formulated research questions and interventions which are easier to implement and evaluate. But academics and practitioners alike need ways to bring evidence and theory to bear on complex challenges and questions that require systemic reforms, even if these are rarely amenable to clean, closed-ended, provably correct solutions. To paraphrase the political scientist Henry Farrell, studies of such questions are impossibly big and likely to be wrong (or at least not fully right), but nonetheless help us understand something important a little bit better.[2]

This book is written in that spirit. It asks a question of first-order importance for both research and practice: how should bureaucratic leaders design and implement systemic reforms? It attempts to answer this question by grounding itself in solid conceptual foundations, systematically collecting a vast amount of data and analyzing it carefully, and using these empirical findings to build a better understanding of why systemic reforms often fail and how they might be approached more successfully. But the answers it generates are not simple, closed-ended, provably correct solutions, because that is not the nature of the research question – or of the task facing reformers. So this book is not intended to be the final word on studying and implementing bureaucratic reforms. Rather, its more modest goals are to help advance the state of empirical evidence and substantive insight on civil service reforms, to contribute some new theoretical ideas and methodological tools, and to encourage more researchers and reformers to grapple with the big, systemic challenges – and opportunities – facing government bureaucracies around the world.

The Challenges of Researching Systemic Reforms

That effective government bureaucracies are essential to prosperous economies, fair and open politics, and healthy societies is a one of the few issues on which there is near-unanimity among academics and practitioners from across the ideological spectrum. This point has been demonstrated by hundreds, if not thousands, of academic studies – not to mention the lived experience of anyone who's ever worked in or depended on a government bureaucracy. If you've picked up this book and made it this far, I take it that you don't need to be convinced that effective bureaucracies that implement policies well and deliver services efficiently are generally a good thing, and that taking steps to improve their performance is important.

When we think about the kind of evidence we'd want to help us do this, both academics and practitioners tend to ask questions like "what is the effect of this intervention or reform on performance", or "what interventions or reforms should I adopt to improve performance?" There are many versions of this question, but they are all variations on the same underlying question of what lever needs to be pulled in order to improve performance. For example, reformers or researchers might investigate the effects of adopting a new performance management policy that aims to link measured performance to some type of rewards or sanctions. (Indeed, this book will show that such policies are among the most common reforms governments adopt to try to improve performance.) Or they might seek to understand whether certain structural variables outside the immediate control of the country's civil service – income levels, colonial or administrative legacies, political competition, and so on – help determine the effectiveness of the civil service.

These are questions of causal inference, and modern social science is increasingly dominated by quantitative and qualitative methods of trying to answer them in precise and rigorous ways, from quantitative randomized control trials or natural experiments to qualitative process tracing. There's a great deal of excellent research on bureaucracies and service delivery in this vein, and it has helped shed more light not just on the effects of incentive schemes on various dimensions of bureaucratic performance but also on selection, monitoring, motivation, funding, and management.[3] I've also contributed to some of this research alongside various co-authors, including through a long-term collaboration with Ghana's Civil Service that has included surveys, qualitative studies, and a randomized control trial – all of which also stemmed from the 2014 conversation with Agyekum-Dwamena that I referred to above.[4]

But despite the importance of these approaches, I want to argue that if we want to adopt an evidence-based approach to learning about reforming civil services at the *system* level, we need to be able to temporarily set aside our causal inference mindsets – or at least augment them with other forms of evidence and insight. There are two main reasons for this.

First, the systemic, multi-faceted nature of large-scale reforms and of bureaucratic performance makes it incredibly difficult to apply causal inference methods at the level of rigor which researchers and evaluators have come to expect. While causal inference approaches of course vary greatly in their methods, they share a set of minimum requirements: interventions or policies that are narrow and precisely specified enough to be coded as a binary or categorical treatment variable(s); exogenous variation in the application of the reform across units of analysis in a way that creates a clean counterfactual or "control" group; and good measures of bureaucratic performance across all (or at least most) dimensions that might be affected by this policy. But system-level civil service reforms nearly always bundle together numerous policies and processes that include both "hard" and "soft" elements, and apply them to the whole of the system (i.e. all units of analysis) simultaneously. And bureaucratic performance is notoriously difficult to measure in a consistent and comprehensive way, especially across ministries and agencies with very different functions and with multiple competing goals and tasks that have different levels of measurability and often require collaboration across various teams and stakeholders.[5] And that's without going into questions of whether the reform cases being studied are representative of the contexts to which we want to apply the evidence. It's not impossible to meet these requirements for applying causal inference methods to large-scale reforms – and researchers should try to do so where possible – but it's definitely easier to do so for micro-level interventions, small-scale pilots, and isolated behavioral nudges, and so the emphasis on obtaining causally identified answers to narrow, closed-ended questions has come to dominate research on changing bureaucracies.

Second, when we ask how to make bureaucracies more effective, every interesting answer is endogenous to the system we are trying to study. To be more precise: the prevailing emphasis on identifying exogenous variation in the explanatory variable of interest can lead researchers to only study variables over which current policymakers have no control – this is the definition of exogenous – and thus inadvertently avoid studying the very processes and situations that reformers might actually be able to change. An extreme example of this are studies that examines how macro-historical or geographic factors have influenced present-day governance

quality.[6] It might be true that these deep and unchangeable variables explain much of the cross-country variation in various measures of government performance. But it's not a very useful insight for a present-day head of civil service, except perhaps in a very abstract sense. Even studies in which researchers collaborate with governments to run field experiments that test a specific policy in a real-world setting are not immune from distortion. While such trials or pilots can generate evidence that is valid and useful in that context, the same features of the setting that often make a valid field experiment possible – leaders' interest in generating and using evidence, involvement of a skilled researcher, performance data availability, careful experimental control, an intervention that is self-contained enough to be delivered to some units but not others – also mark out most such settings as non-typical of bureaucratic contexts more widely. Of course, both macro-historical research and randomized control trials (and many causal inference questions and methods in between) can provide important pieces of the puzzle of understanding bureaucratic performance and improvement. So my point is not that we should do less of them, but rather, that limiting our research to factors or reforms for which we can obtain exogenous variation risks also limiting the type of reforms we study and the contexts in which we study them. If we want to generate empirical evidence and theoretical insight on complex, systemic bureaucratic reforms, we need to be able to ask and answer research questions about reforms that are endogenously adopted and driven.

This Book's Approach

Everything about this book has been profoundly shaped by these intellectual challenges. How can research on systemic reforms be as empirically grounded and as systematic as possible once we let go of the prescriptive strictures of causal inference – especially when the focus of our investigations is on inherently endogenous reforms? What does generalizable knowledge look like when the adoption, implementation, and effects of reforms are subject to high-dimensional complementarities and contextual contingencies? How can we avoid the trap of throwing our hands up in the air and saying that it's all very complex and it all depends, and that no we couldn't possibly use simple, straightforward language to offer a few actionable insights? And what would it look like to build theory on implementing systemic reforms that is parsimonious but not over-simplified, profound but still actionable?

First, the guiding *question* of this book – how should bureaucratic leaders approach the task of systemic reform? – is a deliberately unusual one for an academic manuscript. A more orthodox

approach would be formulate a closed-ended research question ("does *X* cause *Y* ?") that can be answered by deductive testing of a theory-driven, falsifiable hypothesis about the impact of one (exogenous) variable on another variable. And when researchers ask open-ended questions, they often ask variations of the question "what factors cause *Y* ?".[7] My question contains elements of both, while also insisting on seeking answers that are both actionable, practical, and generalizable enough to communicate to non-academics – all in a setting where I've argued that conclusively establishing causal relationships between reform adoption and bureaucratic performance is nearly impossible. This research question is therefore an especially challenging one to tackle, but it is (in my view) the most important question, so I maintain it as my guiding star and aim to find answers that are both useful for decisionmakers and grounded in evidence – incomplete and imperfect as they may be.

Second, the nature of an *answer* to such a question must consist not of a definitive one-size-fits-all solution, but rather an insight into the theoretical *mechanisms* through which reforms succeed or fail that can be applied across a wide range of settings. Researchers and practitioners alike often desire unambiguous, causal answers: reform *X* causes outcome *Y*, adopt this reform and it will improve performance. I've argued that for both practical and conceptual reasons, such evidence is near-impossible to generate for systemic civil service reforms. And even if it could be generated, different governments are facing different challenges at different moments with different existing structures and different reform histories – it should be obvious that there can't be a one-size-fits-all answer to this question that holds across all contexts. Instead, useful and generalizable knowledge about systemic reforms has to consist of a set of mid-range theoretical insights about different parts of the reform process, mental models that reformers can remix and apply to the unique demands, constraints, and opportunities of their own particular contexts. In other words, learning from evidence about reform isn't like having a blueprint that tells you exactly what to do – it's like compiling a toolbox and learning what each tool does and doesn't do, so that you can use these tools to solve your own challenges in your own context. In this book, then, I use empirical evidence to identify and explore what I refer to as *mechanisms of success* and *mechanisms of failure*, patterns that repeat themselves across contexts and that often co-exist within a given reform effort. Learning about these mechanisms is analogous to learning how the tools in the toolbox work, and is the kind of answer that this book aims to provide.

Third, the *scope* of the empirical analysis on which my arguments are based is broad rather than deep. Instead of trying to deeply understand the effects of a small number of cases of reform in great depth or to conduct a deep history of reform in any one country, I study every identifiable effort at system-level, performance-oriented civil service reform in six different African countries over the course of the last 30 years. This includes everything from high-profile reform efforts which are already well-researched to little-known reforms that were announced but never got off the ground and quickly faded into obscurity. (I'll give more details about definitions and scope in a moment.) One advantage of this approach is that it gives me a relatively large sample of reforms to study, and eases the concern of inadvertently picking unrepresentative cases based on existing perceptions of success or failure or on which cases have the most information available about them. Even more importantly, studying many reform efforts across multiple countries makes it possible to start to distinguish broader trends and patterns that occur across many cases, whereas focusing on a single reform or single country often lends itself to identifying a wide and often over-determined range of idiosyncratic failures that seemed to cause success or failure in that particular case. In my conversations, I have often heard the failure of particular reforms attributed to factors like the lack of political will, poor implementation, or a country's work culture. And so reformers often think that a particular reform might have succeeded if only they had tried a bit harder or gotten a bit more lucky, or alternatively that their country is just uniquely unsuited to reform. But when we zoom out we often see *repeated patterns* of similar efforts leading to similar results time and time again, often in quite different contexts. These repeated patterns can then be linked to the type of theoretical mechanisms of success and failure that provide generalizable insight to reformers. Studying a broad scope of reform episodes across several countries thus helps us move from idiosyncratic explanations to generalizable patterns.

The six countries I study are Ghana, Kenya, Nigeria, South Africa, Senegal, and Zambia. My temporal scope is roughly the three decades leading up to 2019 during which improved performance has become a central and explicit goal for bureaucracies worldwide, but my starting year for each country varies between 1986 (Senegal) and 1999 (Nigeria) depending on the timing of key political transitions or reform waves. The countries are all democracies (at least during the periods I study) and have undergone numerous reform efforts, but they span across western, eastern, and southern Africa and are diverse in terms of their size, wealth, and historical legacies. All inherited administrative structures and traditions from their colonial past, but from different countries and with different characters, and these had each evolved and

changed in different ways prior to the time period I study. While not randomly selected or fully representative of the continent, as a sample they strike a balance between comparability and contextual variation. It is important to emphasize that the aim of the book is not to make cross-country inferences about how exogenous characteristics affect reform experiences: the fundamental unit of analysis for the book is the reform effort, not the country, and reform cases differ as much within as across countries. By design, countries that have not been democracies for the majority of the past three decades are out of scope of the book, as the dynamics of civil service reform are considerably different. This book therefore aims to speak mainly to reformers and scholars in countries with democratic, pluralistic political systems. And while I do not gather systematic empirical data on reforms in any countries outside Africa, I do frequently draw on examples and evidence from all over the world – including high-income countries – to motivate my analysis and consider the extent to which the patterns and mechanisms I describe are generalizable.

Within each country, I study system-level, performance-oriented reforms to the core civil service. By core civil service, I mean the central government ministries, departments, and agencies responsible for developing, implementing, and overseeing policy. I focus mostly bureaucrats and administrators and technical experts in offices in the capital or other large cities, rather than nurses, teachers, or local government officials dispersed around the front lines of mass service delivery.[8] By reforms, I mean strategic and intentional structural or managerial changes to the internal administration of civil service organizations, whether de jure or de facto, aimed at improving bureaucratic performance. By performance, I mean the extent to which a government bureaucracy effectively delivers on its goals and objectives, at the level of individuals, organizations, and the civil service as a whole.[9] My focus is not on whether civil services are adopting optimal policies, but about how well they are delivering on the policies they have adopted. And by systemic, I mean reforms that apply not just to a single agency or sector, but to the whole civil service.[10]

My scope thus includes a wide range of reforms, from staff salaries and career structures to individual-level incentives and performance management, organizational performance and management, processes for monitoring and improving service delivery, and more. At the same time, it excludes reforms that take place within a single organization or sector, reforms that are exclusively customer-facing or that affect frontline workers only, reforms that are exclusively oriented around budgeting and fiscal issues, decentralization or other local government

reforms, and anti-corruption interventions. Of course, these kinds of reforms all potentially affect performance, as do many other factors besides reforms, such as politics, leadership, economic conditions, and so on. These are all important and worth studying – and have been extensively – but fall outside the scope of this book.

I collect data on each reform effort from a wide range of sources, both primary and secondary. I try to document: the *content* of what changes the reform aimed to make; the *process* of how it was designed and implemented; the actual *implementation* of the changes it envisioned; the *outcomes* of the reform in terms of changing the everyday behavior of civil servants and improving overall bureaucratic performance (to the extent these are possible to gauge, given the challenges of measurement and causal attribution); and the *politics* surrounding the reform effort, both the "high politics" of parties and elections as well as the "low politics" of workplace relationships and bureaucratic interests. To do this, I draw on nearly 1,000 systematically collected academic studies and government documents, 51 interviews with elite civil servants who were personally involved in designing and implementing these reforms across all six countries, 33 interviews with rank-and-file civil servants who were affected by these reforms (in Ghana and Zambia), and in Ghana archival records from the Office of the Head of Civil Service and Public Records and Archives Department. The amount and reliability of data I am able to gather of course varies dramatically across different reform efforts, and my own data collection and analysis are subject to many of the challenges of measurement and inference I highlighted above. I therefore calibrate the strength of my claims depending on the strength of the underlying evidence, particularly with respect to judgments about the impacts of reforms on bureaucratic behavior and outcomes. But by synthesizing and triangulating across these sources, it is possible to present a rich and fairly comprehensive picture of the design and implementation of dozens of reform efforts across thirty years and six countries.

Applying these criteria, I identified a total of 131 reform efforts across the six countries during this time period. When I began research for this book, I had originally planned to code these reforms in order to undertake quantitative or configurational analysis of how reform content and process were associated with implementation and outcomes, possibly moderated by political context. But the process of compiling data and beginning to analyze it convinced me that such an analysis would be over-simplified and imply false precision at best, misleading and biased at worst. To some extent this was due to challenges of measurement: limited data availability, contradictory accounts, and the inherent ambiguity of many bureaucratic and

political processes meant that it was often challenging to capture basic variables like the end date of each reform with a single number, let alone its implementation process or outcomes. Even more fundamentally, reform episodes couldn't be analyzed as independent cases because the boundaries between reform cases were blurred: each reform built (in part) on what had come before and linked (in part) to other reforms that were ongoing simultaneously. Sometimes these influences reflected positive path dependence and efforts to maintain continuity and complementarity across reforms. Other times the perceived failings of a preceding reform led its successors to try to do the opposite, or simultaneous reforms worked at cross-purposes because they were led by rival institutions. This means that something as simple as counting reforms is difficult – the 131 figure I cited above is indicative, but different approaches to drawing case boundaries could lead to the number being far higher or lower. Trying to analyze these reform efforts as independent cases would be invalid, even without attributing causality to the observed relationships.

Figure 1.1: Countries and Data Sources

	Ghana	Zambia	Kenya	Nigeria	Senegal	South Africa
Government, donor, and media documents	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Existing academic literature	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Interviews with elite reformers	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Interviews with rank-and-file civil servants	✓	✓				
Government archives	✓					

Rather than treating these methodological challenges as "bugs" to be worked around, I decided to treat them as inherent "features" of the phenomenon and processes of systemic civil service reform. So instead of relying on assigning codes to these episodes as discrete cases, I used my data to compile a narrative history of reform in each of the six countries, which presents a rich description of the reforms, their contexts, and their interconnections. These narrative histories serve to collate and harmonize messy data sources and diverse reforms into a format that is fairly consistent across reforms and countries, while still permitting enough flexibility of exposition to capture complexities and nuances that a formal coding would obscure. They then serve as the basis for producing descriptive generalizations about what governments are trying

to do and how they are trying to do it, as well as abductive analysis of mechanisms of failure and of success.

Outline and Main Argument

This book is, in some ways, two books in one. The first book is a narrative history of systemic, performance-oriented civil service reforms in each of the six countries. The second book is a thematically organized analysis of the track record of these reforms and what we learn from them, which draws on the narrative histories as data. However, the first book, containing the country-by-country narrative histories as well as further details of data and methods, is located at the end in an extensive Appendix. The thematic analysis thus comprises the main text of the book, and the contours of my arguments closely follow its structure.

Chapter 2 lays out a theoretical framework and empirical evidence for conceptualizing performance. Consistent with my abductive approach, this chapter focuses on building strong conceptual foundations as a starting point for empirical analysis, not developing hypotheses to be tested. The chapter begins by introducing the book's key theoretical building block: the idea that performance in organizations requires some actions that are *verifiable* (formal) and others that are *non-verifiable* (informal).[11] Formal actions are those that can be precisely specified *ex ante* and measured *ex post*; they are the kind of actions that can be easily described in a manual of standard operating procedures or measured on an annual performance appraisal. Informal actions, on the other hand, encompass all the other crucial actions that workers must undertake to carry out their jobs effectively, but are too unpredictable, too complex, or too unmeasurable to be fully codified. I illustrate these theoretical distinctions with empirical evidence that outputs, individual behaviors, and management processes in public sector organizations all usually have important non-verifiable components. Thinking of public sector performance in this way helps us gain clarity about the core challenge of systemic bureaucratic reform: how can a reform leader (like a Head of Civil Service) design and implement reforms to strengthen the performance both of formal and informal actions by thousands of bureaucrats working on different tasks, in different teams, under different managers, in different organizations?

Part II of the book (Chapters 3-6) is the empirical core of the book, examining the track record of these six countries' reform efforts over the past three decades. It documents how

governments have approached reform, how successful they have been, and what have been the main mechanisms of failure and of success of these reforms.

Chapter 3 presents the key descriptive themes that characterize the history of civil service reforms across the six study countries. Chapter 3 begins by presenting a single reform case (Zambia's Public Service Capacity Building Program, 2000-05) to give a tangible example of the kind of reform episodes this book studies – although these are very diverse, and there is no single "typical" reform. The chapter then builds on this illustrative case by using the full range of data collected on reform histories to answer a basic set of descriptive questions:

1) How frequent have reform efforts been?
2) What has been the content of these reforms – the structures, processes, and practices they have tried to introduce?
3) How successful have reforms been?

In brief, my answers to these descriptive questions are:

1) Reform efforts are very frequent and often overlapping within each country. On average, in each country a new reform effort was launched every 1.3 years, and there were 3.8 reforms simultaneously active (although these numbers are subject to many caveats).
2) Reforms mostly try to achieve similar outcomes in terms of improved performance, and do so mainly by re-packaging and re-combining a few different types of reforms (such as individual-level performance management, salary and career reform, and organizational capacity-focused interventions) into new bundles, meaning that countries try to implement the same types of reforms over and over again.
3) There is no example in my data of a reform that fully met all its goals and most reforms fell far short of their (often over-ambitious) goals, but few are total failures. Most did achieve some of their aims – although more in terms of making changes on paper than in practice, and not always through the mechanisms intended by the reform's designers.

Finally, the chapter examines what factors drive the design and timing of reform efforts, considering three sets of potential factors: the incentives and processes of key stakeholder agencies, in particular international donor organizations and various agencies within

governments; political cycles and time horizons; and the persistence, diffusion, and recurrence of ideas across and within countries. Much existing literature focuses on the roles of donors and politics, suggesting that reforms fail because they are externally imposed and not "owned", because governments are only pretending to reform in order to satisfy external donors and lenders, or because African governments are forced to adopt and imitate models from the Global North rather than developing homegrown solutions.[12] I find some evidence for each of these explanations, but also many cases in which reform implementation falls short despite genuine desire within governments to improve performance and genuine belief among reformers that the proposed solutions were appropriate. Donors and political economy are thus both important parts of the story and often initiate or intrude on reform efforts, but they aren't the whole story, and the reformers I interviewed frequently pointed out ways in which they had had major influence over reforms that from the outside appeared to be driven solely by external donors or political imperatives. Instead, reforms are usually shaped to a significant degree by reformers' own understandings or performance and reform, which are in turn shaped in path-dependent ways by their own idiosyncratic experiences, their institutional socialization, and by international trends and thinking. In sum, mental models, ideas, and inspiration matter. This offers some hope for researchers (like me) who hope that evidence and insight on such reforms might be of practical use as well as academic interest.

Chapter 4 documents the first of the two main mechanisms of reform failure. It shows that the most reforms tended to focus heavily on using *formal structures and processes* to try to force bureaucrats to change their behavior with rules, carrots, and sticks. To illustrate this, the chapter focuses on one of the most common types of reforms introduced across countries: individual-level performance management policies, which aim to systematically link individual bureaucrats' performance to rewards and sanctions. There were 34 total efforts to introduce individual-level performance-linked incentives in these six countries over three decades. But despite careful design and widespread acceptance of the aims of these reforms, there were zero instances in which differentiated rewards and sanctions were actually delivered sustainably and systematically to civil servants. Only two delivered differentiated incentives at all – both of which ceased doing so within a few years – but neither delivered sanctions for poor performance. These failures were rooted in a view of civil servants that focused on introducing carrots and sticks rather than on supporting professionals to do their jobs better. The neglect of the importance of un-formalizable bureaucratic behaviors undermined both the implementation and impact of these policies. This pattern also emerged with respect to other common types of

reforms, such as performance improvement funds, salary structure changes, and organizational performance reviews. These also tended to focus primarily on formal behaviors and on formal rules and processes for changing them, and this helped explain why they so consistently fell short of their goals.

Chapter 5 then examines the second main mechanism of reform failure: reforms were usually conceived of as discrete, one-off, often time-bound interventions. The chapter shows how this *projectization* of reform distorted the expectations, content, implementation, leadership, and politics of reform efforts in ways that undermined their ultimate goal of improving performance. Projectization thus explains a wide range of observed features and patterns of reform, from the overselling of reforms' potential benefits to its tendency towards top-down leadership styles, its focus on formalizable outputs and targets, and its frequent lack of political sustainability. While often politically and bureaucratically convenient, the projectization of reform was thus a second common mechanism through which well-intentioned reforms failed to live up to the expectations set for them.

Chapter 6 turns to investigating reforms' two main mechanisms of success: the creation of opportunities to discuss performance and how to improve it, and the energy and momentum to do so. For example, annual staff appraisal systems never succeeded in changing behavior through carrots and sticks, but sometimes did so by spurring workers to have conversations with their bosses for the first time about what they're responsible for and how they're doing. This mechanism of success was driven almost entirely by non-verifiable behavior changes: meaningful discussions can't be forced, workers can't be directly incentivized to care, and it's hard to drive innovation or problem-solving through pre-defined targets. While the conditions for them to occur were created in large part by changing formal structures and processes, these discussions were also sometimes crowded out by governments' efforts to use these formal systems for accountability and incentivization purposes.

The four chapters of Part II thus paint a rich portrait of the big-picture patterns of reforms and of the repeated mechanisms of failure and of success that emerge when we analyze them collectively. And while this book's main empirical analysis focuses on six countries in Africa, each of the chapters in Part II also presents suggestive evidence that these patterns and mechanisms are also present in many other countries and other regions, including in high-income countries. Of course, these mechanisms manifest to different degrees, in different ways,

and in different combinations across different reform efforts. But while each reform effort is unique in some ways, recognizing these broader patterns can help us step back from the idiosyncrasies of each individual case or context and realize that there is both a need and scope to rethink how we approach systemic reform more generally.

So if Part II of the book focused on the "diagnosis" of the ways in which reforms have failed and succeeded, Part III of the book (Chapters 7-9) revolves around the "prescription". How can we conceptualize what an alternative approach to reform might look like, and assess both its potential and the challenges it would face?

Chapter 7 draws together the empirical analysis of the previous chapters with the theoretical framework on organizational performance from Chapter 2 to develop a theory of reform as *catalyzing an ongoing process of continuous improvement in actual practices*. This theory of reform as process reframes the goal of reform, focusing attention directly on changing the day-to-day work practices of rank-and-file civil servants and their managers rather than implicitly assuming that changes in behavior come from changes in formal rules. It reframes how reforms should be implemented, conceiving of change as an ongoing process of many locally driven changes rather than a master plan rolled out through a one-off project or intervention. And it casts the role of senior leaders in a different light, seeing their task not as driving or forcing reforms from the top down but rather as catalyzing, enabling, and inspiring decentralized local change efforts by thousands of staff and teams spread throughout the whole civil service.

Chapter 8 then examines what reform as a process can look like in practice, by conducting a focused case study of reforms led by Nana Agyekum-Dwamena during his time as Head of Ghana's Civil Service. His decades of experience with projectized reforms had convinced him that when he took charge, he wanted to focus not on introducing new policies or new structures but on improving the implementation of existing ones; on changing the management practices that guide ordinary bureaucrats' behavior and routines on a day-to-day basis; and on transforming the mindsets and culture of civil servants across the various ministries and departments that comprise the Civil Service. This chapter documents these reform efforts as well as their successes and limitations. I was privileged to be conducting research in collaboration with Ghana's Civil Service throughout this time period, alongside several co-authors, at Agyekum-Dwamena's request, so I witnessed many of these discussions and reforms as they unfolded. Not all Ghana's problems were solved and not all efforts at change

were successful. But many were, and overall the evidence paints a picture of a Civil Service that has made gradual yet meaningful improvements in a wide range of areas – all while diverging in many respects from the formula that guided previous reform efforts in Ghana and elsewhere. The chapter closes by discussing how Agyekum-Dwamena navigated the political and institutional challenges that arose in approaching reform as a process.

Chapter 8 also distills this alternative approach into a set of three simple rules of thumb that reformers everywhere can apply to their own contexts:

1. Focus first on what can be done within existing formal rules and processes; think of changing formal rules and processes as a last resort rather than a first step.
2. Approach change as a process of collective learning-by-doing, rather than as rolling out a pre-designed blueprint. The priority should not be to make the perfect plan, but rather to start changing actual practices – even small or apparently minor ones – as early as possible.
3. Decentralize the leadership of reform as much as possible. The role of a leader is to encourage and support dispersed improvement by other actors across the system, rather than to drive it by themself.

Of course, exactly what actions these rules of thumb imply will of course be different in different times and places, and for actors in different roles. And they are general principles rather than rigid guidelines: changes to formal rules are sometimes important, some types of changes ought to be rolled out as discrete projects, and top-down leadership is occasionally necessary. But both theory and the evidence of how and why reforms have persistently fallen short of expectations suggest that reform leaders – whether operating at the level of whole systems, single organizations, or even just their own teams – would generally be better served by using these rules of thumb to guide their thoughts and actions.

Chapter 9 then concludes the book by exploring the nuances and scope of these findings and recommendations. It first examines additional instances where reformers have adopted a process approach (or aspects of it), both within the six countries this book studies as well as from other countries around the world, to better understand its potential and limitations. The chapter then reflects further on the extent to which these patterns and implications also hold for other countries and regions and for other types of reform. It suggests that while there is

suggestive evidence that they are quite general, two of the key factors that might influence the applicability of this book's analysis are the extent to which formal rules and processes are already enforced and complied with in a country, and the extent to which the behaviors a reform is trying to influence are formal and verifiable (as opposed to informal and non-verifiable).

You've likely noticed by now that the book does not have dedicated chapters on two issues that are often discussed in the context of civil service reform in Africa and elsewhere: the role of international donor institutions, and the politics of reform. This is because I made a deliberate decision to focus not on the external forces that constrain or influence reform leaders within country governments, but on reformers' agency and room for maneuver within these constraints. To be sure, donors are important stakeholders and funders in many (but far from all) of the reforms I study, so I do discuss their roles and influence extensively – but always as members of the supporting cast, not as the leading actors. With respect to politics, I treat it the same way that many bureaucrats experience it: neither as an afterthought to technical discussions nor as entirely deterministic of reform opportunities, but rather as inextricably bound up with the technical and organizational aspects of reform. Each of the core chapters therefore integrates analysis of how political considerations have shaped the past track record of reforms and must also be navigated by any alternative approach, while still foregrounding the agency of reformers in doing so.[13]

Finally, it's important to emphasize that this book has many allies and cousins in its effort to rethink how we conceptualize behavior, performance, and change in organizations in general and public bureaucracies in particular. In the realm of academic research, scholars from diverse fields and perspectives have written about bottom-up approaches to reform, relational contracts theories of management practices, backward mapping in policy implementation, continuous improvement, process-oriented methods for studying organizational change, problem-solving and muddling as change strategies, the importance of organizational cultures and bureaucratic autonomy, transformational leadership and system leadership, the building of pockets of bureaucratic effectiveness, polycentric governance, and problem-driven iterative adaptation (PDIA) and other complexity science-inspired ways of thinking – to name just a few of the areas of existing literature that this book connects with, draws inspiration from, and seeks to build on.[14] And reformers around the world have been grappling with these ideas for far longer than academics have been writing about them.

So in analyzing how past reform efforts have fallen short and what a better approach might look like, I don't mean to imply that no one else has ever recognized any of these challenges before or tried to experiment with solutions. Still less do I want to suggest that overcoming these challenges is easy. On the contrary, systemic bureaucratic reform is complex and difficult, both conceptually and practically, and most past reforms were themselves the product of smart, dedicated people trying their best to piece together something that they thought would work. I don't pretend that this book has all the answers, but I hope that reading it helps you feel at least a little better prepared than I was the next time a head of civil service – or a minister, mayor, CEO, manager, or other leadership figure – calls you into their office and says, "I want to change the way this place works, but I'm not quite sure how to go about it…"

Endnotes

[1] Among a range of important multi-country studies on civil service reform in Africa, see for example Adamolekun (1999), Levy and Kpundeh (2004), Ayee (2008), Mutahaba (2013), and Basheka and Tshombe (2017), as well as numerous other studies cited elsewhere in this book.
[2] I am grateful for Henry for describing his own impossibly ambitious but important project in these terms, and for allowing me to borrow the phrase.
[3] A full review of this vast literature is beyond the scope of this book, but see for example recent reviews by Finan *et al* (2017), Pepinsky *et al* (2017) and Besley *et al* (2021).
[4] See Rasul *et al* (2021), Williams and Yecalo-Tecle (2020), and Azulai *et al* (2023).
[5] See for example Talbot (2010) on measuring performance, Wilson (1989), Dixit (2002), and Chun and Rainey (2005) on multiple competing goals, and Rasul and Rogger (2018), Rasul *et al* (2021), Khan (2023) on the differential measurability and joint production of bureaucratic tasks, and Boston (2000) and Ang (2017) for more generalized discussions on methodological challenges of evaluating systemic reforms.
[6] See for example Besley and Persson (2011), Acemoglu and Robinson (2012), and Wilfahrt (2021) on the macro-historical determinants of governance quality, Herbst (2000) on geographical determinants of state capacity, and Levy (2014), Appiah and Abdulai (2017), and Hickey and Hossain (2019) on the impact of political economy context on reform.
[7] Goertz and Mahoney (2012) refer to this as research about "the effects of causes" and the "causes of effects", respectively.
[8] The distinction between core and frontline civil servants is blurry both conceptually and in practice. There is also significant variation across countries in the extent to which frontline staff like nurses or teachers are part of the same organizational structures and personnel management systems as administrators or technical experts sitting in ministry headquarters, and hence variation in whether such frontline staff are covered by the reforms I study. I try as much as possible to maintain the conceptual distinction in my data collection and analysis, although official documents and interviewees do not always make this same distinction. This notwithstanding, my analysis should be read as applying directly to reform of the core civil service only.
[9] See Talbot (2010) for a discussion on debates around the definition of performance and the nuances of conceptualizing it in civil service organizations.
[10] By "whole civil service" I mean the whole of the core civil service, subject to the conceptual and practical blurriness discussed above.
[11] This distinction builds on the concept of verifiability, introduced by Williamson (1985) and subsequently foundational to much of contract theory and organizational economics (e.g. Hart and Moore 2008), and adapts it to a public sector bureaucracy context in which the undertaking actions and tasks is a more suitable basis for analysis of performance than transactions (to which the terminology was originally applied).
[12] Within a large literature, see for example Andrews (2013), Andrews *et al* (2017) and Foli and Ohemeng (2021) on mimetic pressures and the transplantation of models that are inappropriate fits for context, and van de Walle (2001) and Obong'o (2015) on political resistance to reform.
[13] On the political economy of reform, see for example van de Walle (2001), Ohemeng and Anebo (2012), Srivastava and Larizza (2013), and Hassan and Kodouda (2022), in addition to works cited earlier.
[14] See for example Polidano (2001), Pollitt and Bouckaert (2004), Ayee (2008), and McCourt (2013) on bottom-up reform approaches; Gibbons and Henderson (2012) and Baron and Kreps (2013) on relational contracts approaches to management practices; Elmore (1979) on backward mapping; Berwick (1989), Bhuiyan and Baghel (2005), Yurkofsky et al (2020), and Bryk et al (2023) on continuous improvement; Pettigrew (1990), Orlikowski (1996), Feldman (2000), and Tsoukas and Chia (2002) on process approaches to organizational change; Lindblom (1959), Heclo (1974), Andrews (2013), and Bersch (2019) on muddling and problem-solving; Grindle (1997), Tendler (1997), Leonard (2010), Roll (2013), Honig (2018), McDonnell (2020), and Mangla (2022) on bureaucratic cultures, autonomy, and organizational effectiveness; and Olaopa (2011) and Andrews et al (2017) on complexity and problem-driven iterative adaptation. Chapter 7 discusses these areas of literature more extensively.